



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 21

MARYLAND

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Maryland's family courts and child-welfare system.

31

MARYLAND FAMILIES ON RECORD · 55
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
12 OF 24

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MARYLAND AT A GLANCE.

Across 31 Maryland families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 55 30 of 31 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$17,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 32.3% 19.4% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 31	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.8	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 30 of 31	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 12

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Maryland families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF MARYLAND FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	21	\$17,000	\$75,429	\$1,584,000
Lost Wages	12	\$9,000	\$279,917	\$3,359,000
Other Court Fees	5	\$2,000	\$3,540	\$17,700
Therapy / Evaluations	6	\$1,000	\$4,500	\$27,000
Reunification Services	8	\$0	\$550	\$4,400
GAL Fees	7	\$0	\$7,571	\$53,000
Asset Loss	8	\$40,000	\$779,375	\$6,235,000
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$69,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		26	2.2 yrs
Total across all families		473	39.4 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MARYLAND

Most families documenting in Maryland are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		13	42%
Active case: stuck or delayed		13	42%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		3	10%
Case closed: within last 2 years		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only		14	45%
Both Family Court and CPS		8	26%
Unknown		5	16%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		3	10%
Family Court		1	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		6	19%
3 – 5 years		6	19%
Over 10 years		4	13%
6 months – 1 year		3	10%
5 – 10 years		3	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		12	39%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		10	32%
50/50 Joint		3	10%
Full Custody		2	6%
Partial / Shared		2	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Allegheny		2	6%
Washington		2	6%
Prince George's		2	6%
Carroll		2	6%
Frederick		1	3%
Cecil		1	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		10	32%
Other: (Short answer)		7	23%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		3	10%
High Conflict Divorce		2	6%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		2	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — MARYLAND

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



The system has ripped away my rights and any stability I had provided my son over the last decade. It's SHAMEFUL!!!

— RACHEL

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Judge denied motions to stop reunification efforts despite evidence of medical harm. GAL suppressing all evidence. GAL is lying and helping defendant, has not done a proper investigation, 100% one sided. Jumped on alienation narrative and ignores the defendant's felony [...]

— MARYLAND PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM MARYLAND

The system came in and ripped my daughter out of my arms with no due process and created years of severe, debilitating separation anxiety for her.

— NICOLE

CPS has filed to terminate my rights completely for my two older children. I was never informed of the 15-22 months “timeframe” they lied on every single court report and never acknowledged any progress I made

— HANNAH

CPS succeeded in traumatizing my children worse than any argument my kids father and I ever had. We have been living apart and in other relationships for a year now and I just got Unsupervised with my smallest child who was removed two days before Christmas after a YEAR of [...]

— TYLER

The system has completely destroyed my life. It has taken my child, my career and my freedom based off lies and false allegations with no evidence, in fact my accuser used the things they were doing to me as their defense and I was maliciously prosecuted instead of them because [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They are taking a dedicated full-time mother almost completely away from her children. And gave them to my ex-husband who was never present.

— JESSICA

Ex and wife never wanted the children. They just didn't want me to have the children. Covert-insidious form of abuse. Children aged out of the system. Ex hasn't contacted children in months/years. Adult children are still traumatized and in therapy.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Have destroyed my faith in the country live and fought and killed for. I lost my children, my life financial I'm struggling and I don't wish to happen to anyone.

— ABU

Broke mother and dimmed three childrens lights spirits and souls causing severe distrust and perpetual fear of abuser

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn us apart lost of stability

— SCOTT

Separated my two minor children. Placed my daughter in the arms of an abuser. Missed Drs. Appointments for chronically ill daughter and then stated they are just routine appointments when I told the court her dad was not taking her while in his custody

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This is been absolutely devastating for me but terroristically traumatizingfir my intentionally parented baby who's world has been turned upside down for profit. I am beyond mortified but determined to correct my mistakes and rescue my Baby Girl

— NIKKI

It's taken away our ability to advocate and protect our children. They're in danger everyday and we can't do anything to help them. No matter how we fight to protect them it's twisted as abuse towards the ex partner.....never do they look at the abuse towards the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system treated her word as fact and her lies as evidence. Treated me as a criminal

— WILL

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Broken my soul Made me sick I lost so much

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

To the mothers suffering from post partum dealing with the threat of having your infant taken is inhumane to all mothers but especially the ones in this delicate time contact me if need be I dont mind I would love to expose this corruption, my instagram is @blissfullyblunt I am [...]

— REBECCA

It has failed me. Not allowing me to be a father

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has allowed my children's father's mother to intervene on his behalf of ONE of our three children, his entire eight years of existence. While trusting my other two children to be with me full-time, they have allowed this woman to abuse, my son, myself and my entire [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered it entirely

— SHERRI

The system has empowered my ex-wife with control, removed my son from my life, removed my daughter from my life. It was beaten me mentally as I just want to love my kids and give them the best things that I can but am no longer able to due to financial burden of using a lawyer [...]

— JOHN

My family and their associates all assisted in attempted murder, and kidnapping of my child. There is trafficking and other crimes involved. Several counties and the FBI refused assistance when reported repeatedly for over a year. They stole my home my child and my finances.

— KACIE

After having primary custody for over 8 years and being the primary caregiver for 14 years. the court decided to change custody in because of a military relocation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

23 Maryland parents submitted ranked quotes. 23 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/md.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Maryland report comes from Maryland respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Maryland — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 31 Maryland families reporting here are not the universe of Maryland families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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